

The Move-In Week Survival Kit

Your complete guide to surviving (and thriving)
during your first week in a new apartment

Interactive Edition

Fill-in checklists, planners & trackers

SmallSpaceHome.ca

\$9 CAD

What Kind of Mover Are You?

Check the answer that sounds most like you for each question.

1. Your moving day is in two weeks. You:

- ☐ A. Have a colour-coded spreadsheet, timeline, and labelling system ready
- ☐ B. Throw stuff in bags the night before and figure it out
- ☐ C. Text five friends asking who has a truck and is free

2. You arrive at the new place. First thing you do?

- ☐ A. Walk through every room with a checklist documenting issues
- ☐ B. Toss your mattress on the floor - sleep setup done
- ☐ C. Call your most organized friend to come help direct traffic

3. The kitchen needs to be set up. Your approach?

- ☐ A. Drawer organizers, labelled shelves, everything has a place
- ☐ B. Pile dishes in cupboards, worry about it later
- ☐ C. Order pizza and let someone else figure out the kitchen

4. You need to change your address everywhere. You:

- ☐ A. Work through a master list of every account systematically
- ☐ B. Change things as they come up when mail bounces back
- ☐ C. Ask a friend or family member to help coordinate

5. By Day 7, your place looks:

- ☐ A. Magazine-ready with everything unpacked and organized
- ☐ B. Liveable-ish with a few mystery boxes in the corner
- ☐ C. Great, thanks to the army of helpers who came through

TIP

Mostly A's: The Planner - you thrive on spreadsheets and systems. Mostly B's: The Wing-It - you figure it out as you go. Mostly C's: The Delegator - you know your strength is enlisting help. All types can nail move-in week - this book meets you where you are!

Chapter 1

The First Hour

Time estimate: 30-60 minutes

The first hour sets the tone for everything. Before you unpack a single box, do these critical tasks.

Photo Walkthrough

Document EVERYTHING for your deposit. Take photos and video of:

- ☐ Every wall, floor, and ceiling in each room
- ☐ Inside all cupboards and closets
- ☐ All appliances (open fridge, oven, dishwasher)
- ☐ Windows, locks, and screens
- ☐ Bathroom fixtures (taps, toilet, tub/shower)
- ☐ Any existing damage, marks, or stains

DO THIS NOW

- >> Open your phone camera right now
- >> Walk through every room systematically
- >> Email photos to yourself with date in subject line

Test All Utilities

- ☐ Hot and cold water in kitchen and bathroom
- ☐ All light switches and outlets
- ☐ Stove/oven burners
- ☐ Fridge is running and cold
- ☐ Heat/AC works
- ☐ Toilet flushes properly
- ☐ Smoke detectors have batteries

First Essentials to Buy

- ☐ Plunger (\$8-10) - do not skip this
- ☐ Toilet paper (at least 4 rolls)
- ☐ Sheets and a pillow for tonight
- ☐ Basic cleaning spray and paper towels
- ☐ Box cutter / scissors
- ☐ Hand soap
- ☐ Garbage bags
- ☐ Phone charger accessible (not buried in a box)

Documents to Collect

Lease location / copy stored at:

Landlord name:

Landlord phone:

Landlord email:

Building rules / tenant handbook location:

Parking spot / rules:

TIP

Find parking FIRST. Nothing is worse than circling the block with a loaded moving truck.

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ Photo walkthrough completed and emailed to self
- ☐ All utilities tested and working
- ☐ First essentials purchased
- ☐ Landlord contact info recorded
- ☐ Parking figured out

Chapter 2

Unpack by Zone

Time estimate: spread across Days 1-3

Do NOT try to unpack everything at once. Work in zones, in this order.

Zone 1: Bedroom (Priority #1)

Sleep matters most. An exhausted you makes bad decisions about everything else.

- ☐ Make the bed with clean sheets
- ☐ Set up bedside table or surface
- ☐ Plug in phone charger
- ☐ Hang or store 3 days of clothes
- ☐ Set up lamp or light source

Zone 2: Bathroom

- ☐ Hang towels
- ☐ Set out soap, shampoo, toothbrush
- ☐ Place toilet paper on holder
- ☐ Put out bath mat
- ☐ Stock basic medicine (pain relief, bandaids)

Zone 3: Kitchen (Minimal)

- ☐ Unpack: 2 plates, 2 bowls, 2 mugs, basic cutlery
- ☐ Set up coffee maker or kettle
- ☐ Put out dish soap and sponge
- ☐ Stock paper towels
- ☐ One pot, one pan, one cutting board

Zone 4: Everything Else

This can wait. Seriously.

TIP

The First-Night Box: Pack one box last (load it on the truck last, unload first) with: sheets, pillow, PJs, toiletries, phone charger, snacks, TP, towel, change of clothes. Label it clearly.

The One-Week Rule

If a box sits untouched for 7 days after move-in, seriously reconsider whether you need what is inside. This is a great decluttering signal.

The Layering Principle

Your space does not need to be finished on Day 1. Layer things in over time: function first, then comfort, then

style. Do not buy decor during move-in week.

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ Bedroom set up and sleepable
- ☐ Bathroom functional
- ☐ Kitchen has minimal setup for meals
- ☐ First-night box concept understood

Chapter 3

Address Registration

Time estimate: 2-hour block

Set aside one focused block to knock out all address changes. Doing them piecemeal means you will forget something.

DO THIS NOW

- >> Block 2 hours in your calendar for address changes
- >> Have your new address written down beside you
- >> Open your browser with all account logins ready

Master Address Change List

- ☐ Driver's license (provincial - do within 30 days)
- ☐ Health card (provincial)
- ☐ Bank accounts and credit cards
- ☐ Employer / payroll / HR
- ☐ CRA (Canada Revenue Agency) - online via My Account
- ☐ Auto insurance
- ☐ Tenant / renter's insurance
- ☐ Cell phone provider
- ☐ Streaming subscriptions (Netflix, Spotify, etc.)
- ☐ Online shopping accounts (Amazon, etc.)
- ☐ Gym membership
- ☐ Dentist and doctor
- ☐ Voter registration
- ☐ Vehicle registration
- ☐ Loyalty programs and rewards cards

Canada Post Mail Forwarding

Cost: approximately \$75/year. Set up at canadapost.ca or in person. Redirects mail from old address to new for 12 months.

Mail forwarding start date:

Confirmation number:

TIP

Do your address changes on a weekday when phone support lines are open, in case any accounts need a call instead of an online change.

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ All accounts on list updated
- ☐ Canada Post forwarding set up
- ☐ IDs updated within required timeframe

Chapter 4

Utilities Setup

Time estimate: 1-2 hours (plus lead time)

Some utilities need to be booked weeks in advance. Others can be set up on move-in day.

DO THIS NOW

- >> Book internet installation 2 weeks before move-in
- >> Confirm hydro/electricity transfer date with provider

Internet

Book at least 2 weeks early. Installation appointments fill up fast.

Provider:

Account number:

Installation date:

Wifi network name:

Wifi password:

Hydro / Electricity

Provider:

Account number:

Transfer/start date:

Other Utilities

Gas provider / account (if applicable):

Water (if separate from rent):

TIP

Check your lease: many apartments include water and sometimes heat in rent. Know what you are responsible for before setting anything up.

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ Internet booked and installed
- ☐ Hydro/electricity transferred to your name
- ☐ All utility account numbers recorded

Chapter 5

Tenant Insurance

Time estimate: 30 minutes

This is NOT optional. Get tenant insurance before you move in. It costs \$15-30/month and protects everything you own.

What It Covers

- Theft of your belongings
- Fire damage to your possessions
- Liability (someone gets hurt in your unit)
- Additional living expenses if your unit becomes unliveable

What It Usually Does NOT Cover

- Flood / sewer backup (usually extra rider)
- Earthquake (usually extra)
- Intentional damage
- Wear and tear on the unit itself

DO THIS NOW

- >> Get 2-3 quotes online (takes 10 minutes each)
- >> Ask about sewer backup / flood coverage
- >> Set up policy BEFORE move-in day

Insurance provider:

Policy number:

Monthly cost:

Coverage amount:

Start date:

TIP

Many landlords now REQUIRE tenant insurance. Even if yours does not, the cost of replacing everything you own far exceeds \$15-30/month.

End-of-Chapter Checklist

Chapter 6

The Landlord Relationship

Time estimate: ongoing

A good landlord relationship makes your tenancy smooth. A bad one makes it miserable. Set the tone early.

Golden Rules

- Document EVERYTHING in writing (email, not just text)
- Know your provincial tenant rights
- Be professional - friendly, but not friends
- Keep records of all communication
- Pay rent on time, every time
- Report maintenance issues promptly and in writing

Know Your Rights

- Your landlord must give 24 hours notice before entering (in most provinces)
- Maintenance requests have reasonable timelines
- Rent increases are regulated (check your province)
- You cannot be evicted without proper legal process

TIP

Start a dedicated email folder or label for all landlord communication. If something ever goes to a tribunal, written records are everything.

Landlord preferred contact method:

Maintenance request process:

Rent payment method and due date:

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ Landlord contact info saved in phone
- ☐ Communication channel established
- ☐ Tenant rights reviewed for your province
- ☐ Rent payment method set up

Chapter 7

The First Week Plan

Day-by-day schedule

Follow this day-by-day plan to stay sane. You do not have to do everything. Check off what you complete each day.

Day 1: Arrive & Sleep Setup

- ☐ Complete first-hour checklist (Chapter 1)
- ☐ Set up bedroom (Zone 1)
- ☐ Set up bathroom (Zone 2)
- ☐ Order or buy dinner - do NOT try to cook tonight

Day 2: Kitchen & Eating

- ☐ Set up kitchen basics (Zone 3)
- ☐ First small grocery run (basics only)
- ☐ Cook or prep one simple meal
- ☐ Start unpacking living area

Day 3: Living Areas

- ☐ Arrange living room furniture
- ☐ Set up TV / entertainment if applicable
- ☐ Unpack remaining priority boxes
- ☐ Take out first round of recycling/garbage

Day 4: Admin Day

- ☐ Address changes (Chapter 3) - block 2 hours
- ☐ Utility confirmations (Chapter 4)
- ☐ Tenant insurance (Chapter 5)
- ☐ Set up mail forwarding if not done

Day 5: Explore

- ☐ Walk around your neighbourhood
- ☐ Find nearest grocery store
- ☐ Locate nearest pharmacy
- ☐ Test your commute to work/school
- ☐ Find a coffee shop you like

Day 6: Organize

- ☐ Tackle remaining boxes
- ☐ Apply the one-week rule to untouched boxes
- ☐ Do first load of laundry in new machines
- ☐ Buy any remaining household items

Day 7: Rest & Enjoy

- ☐ You made it - take it easy today
- ☐ Cook a real meal in your kitchen
- ☐ Sit on your couch and do nothing for 30 minutes
- ☐ Appreciate your new space

Notes for the week:

Things I still need to do:

Chapter 8

First Grocery Shop

Time estimate: 45 minutes

Your first grocery run should be small and strategic. Do NOT stock a full pantry on Day 1. You do not know what you need yet.

Starter Pantry (Under \$50)

- ☐ Salt and pepper
- ☐ Cooking oil (olive or vegetable)
- ☐ Butter
- ☐ Rice or pasta (1 box/bag)
- ☐ Pasta sauce (1 jar)
- ☐ Eggs (1 dozen)
- ☐ Bread
- ☐ Peanut butter
- ☐ Coffee or tea
- ☐ Milk
- ☐ Cheese (block or shredded)
- ☐ Chicken breasts or ground meat
- ☐ Onions (bag of 3)
- ☐ Garlic
- ☐ Canned beans (2 cans)
- ☐ Canned tomatoes (1 can)
- ☐ Frozen vegetables (1 bag)
- ☐ Bananas
- ☐ Apples
- ☐ Dish soap and sponge

Budget for first grocery shop: \$

Actual spent: \$

TIP

Kitchen setup priorities: kettle or coffee maker first, then one good pot, one pan, one cutting board, and one sharp knife. Everything else can wait.

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ First grocery run completed

Chapter 9

The First Month

Time estimate: ongoing

Week one is survival. Month one is about building your life in your new space.

Establish Routines

- ☐ Morning routine that works in this space
- ☐ Meal prep or cooking schedule
- ☐ Cleaning routine (even 15 min/day)
- ☐ Garbage and recycling schedule memorized
- ☐ Laundry schedule

Get to Know Your Area

- ☐ Introduce yourself to at least one neighbour
- ☐ Find your go-to grocery store
- ☐ Find your go-to coffee shop
- ☐ Locate nearest gym or fitness option
- ☐ Test commute at actual commute time
- ☐ Find nearest park or green space
- ☐ Locate library

Garbage day:

Recycling day:

My go-to grocery store:

My go-to coffee shop:

Nearest gym:

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ Basic routines established
- ☐ Neighbourhood explored
- ☐ Garbage/recycling schedule known

Chapter 10

First Repair

Time estimate: varies

Something will break or need fixing. Here is how to handle it.

DIY vs Call Landlord

CALL YOUR LANDLORD for:

- Plumbing issues (leaks, clogs you cannot fix)
- Electrical problems
- Appliance breakdowns
- Heating/cooling failure
- Pest issues
- Structural problems (windows, doors, locks)

DIY (your responsibility):

- Changing light bulbs
- Minor toilet clogs (hence the plunger)
- Tightening loose screws on handles
- Replacing batteries in smoke detectors
- Hanging pictures (with approval)

Basic Toolkit (\$25-30)

- ☐ Screwdriver set (Phillips and flat)
- ☐ Hammer
- ☐ Measuring tape
- ☐ Pliers
- ☐ Level
- ☐ Picture hanging kit
- ☐ Flashlight

DO THIS NOW

- >> Save landlord emergency maintenance number in phone
- >> Know the difference: emergency vs non-emergency
- >> Emergency = flood, no heat in winter, gas smell, break-in

Emergency maintenance number:

Non-emergency maintenance process:

End-of-Chapter Checklist

Chapter 11

First Guest

Time estimate: 30 minutes to prep

Having your first guest over is a milestone. It means your place is starting to feel like home.

Quick-Clean Routine (30 min)

- ☐ Wipe kitchen counters and sink
- ☐ Clean bathroom (toilet, sink, mirror)
- ☐ Vacuum or sweep main areas
- ☐ Tidy living room - clear surfaces
- ☐ Take out garbage
- ☐ Light a candle or open a window for fresh air

Guest Essentials

- ☐ Clean towel set aside for guest
- ☐ Basic toiletries accessible (soap, toothpaste)
- ☐ Wifi password written down or easy to share
- ☐ Extra blanket and pillow if staying over
- ☐ Drinks to offer (water, tea, coffee)

TIP

Make it feel like home for YOU first, then worry about guests. Your first guest will not judge your boxes in the corner. They are happy for you.

Wifi password to share with guests:

End-of-Chapter Checklist

- ☐ Quick-clean routine practiced
- ☐ Guest essentials ready
- ☐ Wifi password easily shareable

Chapter 12

You're Settled

You made it!

If you are reading this, you survived move-in week. Take a moment to appreciate that.

Signs You're Home

- You know where everything is (mostly)
- You have a morning routine that works
- You can cook a meal without searching for utensils
- You have a favourite spot to sit
- The space smells like you, not the last tenant
- You stopped calling it 'the new place'

Celebrate this milestone. Moving is one of the most stressful life events, and you handled it.

What's Next for Your Space

Now that survival mode is over, you can start thinking about making this space truly yours. But there is no rush. Three things I want to do with this space eventually:

1.

2.

3.

Master Move-In Checklist

The complete list. Print this out and check items off as you go.

Before Move-In

- ☐ Book internet installation (2 weeks early)
- ☐ Get tenant insurance quotes and purchase policy
- ☐ Set up Canada Post mail forwarding
- ☐ Pack first-night box
- ☐ Confirm move-in date and key pickup with landlord

First Hour

- ☐ Photo walkthrough of entire unit
- ☐ Test all utilities
- ☐ Find parking
- ☐ Buy essentials (plunger, TP, sheets, cleaning supplies)
- ☐ Collect lease and landlord contact info

Day 1-2

- ☐ Set up bedroom
- ☐ Set up bathroom
- ☐ Set up kitchen basics
- ☐ First grocery run

Day 3-4

- ☐ Arrange living areas
- ☐ Complete address changes (2-hour block)
- ☐ Confirm all utility accounts
- ☐ Set up internet

Day 5-7

- ☐ Explore neighbourhood
- ☐ Test commute
- ☐ Tackle remaining boxes
- ☐ Apply one-week rule
- ☐ Rest and enjoy your new space

First Month

- ☐ Establish cleaning routine

- ☐ Memorize garbage/recycling schedule
- ☐ Meet at least one neighbour
- ☐ Find go-to grocery store, pharmacy, coffee shop
- ☐ Purchase basic toolkit
- ☐ Save emergency maintenance number
- ☐ Host first guest

Important Information

Fill this in and keep it handy. This is your quick-reference page.

Landlord & Building

Landlord name:

Landlord phone:

Landlord email:

Building manager name:

Building manager phone:

Emergency maintenance number:

Utilities

Internet provider / account #:

Wifi network name:

Wifi password:

Hydro provider / account #:

Gas provider / account # (if applicable):

Tenant insurance provider / policy #:

Schedule

Garbage pickup day:

Recycling pickup day:

Rent due date:

Rent payment method:

Nearby Essentials

Nearest hospital / urgent care:

Nearest pharmacy:

Nearest grocery store:

Non-emergency police line:

You're Home!

Congratulations on your new space.
You survived move-in week.

My move-in date:

Things I Love About My New Place:

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

SmallSpaceHome.ca

Making small spaces work beautifully.